

UTT Chapter 02 Assignment

Hey there!

Intramurals have started up here at the university, and I've joined one of the soccer teams! I met a girl named Sarah (she's on my team), and we've chatted a few times. The other day after practice, I asked Sarah how her weekend was, and she said she had a great time clubbing with some friends on Saturday night. I asked her what she did on Sunday, and she laughed at me. I guess she stayed out so late that she didn't wake up until one or two p.m. Well, I was up much earlier than that. I did play quite a bit of ultimate Frisbee with my roommate on Saturday, but I wasn't too tired for church on Sunday morning. I guess Sarah doesn't go to church. She doesn't even believe in God. As a biochem major, she said she doesn't believe in anything she can't investigate with her five senses. As she put it, "If God existed, why hasn't he made himself known?"

I knew she was wrong. So I told her that God *has* made himself known—through Jesus Christ. That's how I know him! She smiled wryly and asked, "Have you ever seen him? Have you touched him? Have you heard him?" I didn't quite know how to respond to her. Of course I haven't seen God, but I still know he's real.

I told her that the most convincing element of Christianity for me is the evidence of my changed life. Through Christ, God saved me from my sin and ultimately from myself. She asked defensively if I thought everyone needed saving from sin and from themselves. Of course, I told her yes. Everyone needs Jesus.

She replied that she, for one, was doing just fine on her own. She told me she didn't think there was anything wrong with her, so there's nothing for God to fix. And she wondered why I would believe all this "Jesus talk" without any evidence that he actually exists.

I told her that's exactly what faith is; it's believing something in spite of the evidence. If we knew everything, we wouldn't need to have faith, right? She just laughed at me, shaking her head condescendingly. She told me that "blind faith" might work for Christians, but she would only believe in something if there were good evidence for doing so.

As you can see, I got myself into a bit of a bind. I know I have good reasons for believing everything I told her, but I am having trouble articulating it. I wonder if you could help! I know God has revealed himself, but **in what ways has God made himself known?** I was also confused when I told her why I need Jesus. I know we all need Jesus. I know we all sin, but **what's wrong with humanity?** And **what is God's plan for redeeming humanity?** Lastly, her comments about "blind faith" unsettled me as well. I've always thought that faith was blind, but I wish that it wasn't. **Is biblical faith really blind?** I hope you can help me out!

Gotta go! Bye!
-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. In what ways has God made himself known?

God has revealed himself in two ways: general and special revelation. **General revelation** refers to the design and beauty inherent within the created world, which point us to God's existence and nature. This knowledge is available to everyone, and it can bring us to a general understanding of who God is, what he's like, and how he made the world. However, general revelation cannot bring us to a personal or saving knowledge of God. Only **special revelation**—the ways God has spoken to us through the Bible and his Spirit—gives more in-depth and personal knowledge of God. Only this type of knowledge offers salvation. [2.4]

2. What is wrong with humanity?

Because Adam and Eve disobeyed God, the entire created order is fractured. Death and decay have touched every aspect of creation, and we now have a sinful nature within us that despises God and loves sin. Because of our love for sin, we exist under God's wrath. We cannot save ourselves; we need divine intervention. [2.7c]

3. What is God's plan for redeeming humanity?

God reached down into our broken situation to give us a solution to our depravity—himself. He came and bore our burdens, understood our brokenness, died as a sacrifice for our sin, and rose again displaying victory over the grave. Christ now sits at God's right hand interceding on our behalf. Because of his selfless sacrifice, we are no longer slaves to our sin, nor will we bear the eternal punishment for it. [2.7c]

4. Is biblical faith really blind?

Contrary to popular belief, the Christian faith is not opposed to—or weakened by—the presence of reason. Although some Christians have adopted their faith blindly, faith is not defined as “blind” trust. Take Paul's ministry as an example. In Acts 17, we find Paul “reasoning” with the Jews and later debating the evidence of Christ's resurrection with the academics of his day. Paul didn't go around asking people to blindly believe in God. He appealed to their reason. God is rational, reasonable, and worthy of our trust. Our faith should be grounded upon this and not wishful thinking. [2.9]